Soviet missile capable of reaching the moon, leaving it to Khrushchev, who wanted to reach the United States, not the moon, to stop the fight. Loyal but ineffective, Moskalenko had to go. Khrushchev later recalled that in his opinion there were three Moskalenkos: a brave and energetic general; a rude administrator insensitive to his subordinates and prone to hysterics; and, finally, a careerist. He decided to fire all three Moskalenkos: on April 24, 1962, his former protégé was shifted to the post of inspector in chief of the Ministry of Defense and replaced in his former office by the commander of the Soviet Air Defense Forces, Marshal Sergei Biriuzov.[13]

With Moskalenko gone, Biriuzov appointed, and plans for new missiles in the works, Khrushchev still needed a quick solution to his missile-gap problem. Surprisingly, he found it on his trip to Bulgaria, where Cuba and missiles were much on his mind. The solution he came up with involved both.

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ON MAY 12, TWO DAYS BEFORE LEAVING MOSCOW FOR SOFIA, Khrushchev met with a visiting American, someone as close to President Kennedy as could be—the White House press secretary, Pierre Salinger. He found time to take Salinger on a boat ride on the Moscow River, spending a total of fourteen hours with him. Khrushchev lashed out at Kennedy's recent remark to the effect that he did not exclude a nuclear strike against the Soviet Union. "Of course, in some circumstances we must be prepared to use nuclear weapon at the start, come what may—a clear attack on Western Europe, for example," the president had said, trying to explain that the appearance of Soviet intercontinental missiles had shifted the balance of power and made the Eisenhower administration's plan to strike without possibility of retaliation obsolete. Kennedy had soon retracted his remark, but that did not satisfy Khrushchev, who responded furiously both in his private conversations with Salinger and in public.[14]

Speaking to the extremely friendly crowd in Sofia, Khrushchev said that Kennedy "had not hesitated even to declare that under certain circumstances the United States might take 'the initiative in a nuclear